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WHY MASS. LOST ITS MOJO — AND HOW WE GET IT BACK

Another success story that got away

Mass. native's exodus
West reinforces where
state comes up short

By Emma Platoff
GLOBE STAFF

REDWOOD CITY, Calif. — By all rights, Felix Wong and his company should be in Massachusetts. Wong, 33, was born in Quincy, graduated from Braintree High School, and spent a decade living in Cambridge, where he earned two degrees from Harvard and worked as a postdoc at MIT. His parents still live in Massachusetts, and he now leads a startup in biotech, an industry Boston has owned for the better part of two decades.

But on a recent Wednesday, Wong was in sunny Silicon Valley, walking in the shade of the jacaranda trees near the hiking trail outside his office and reflecting on the creative spirit of California. “There’s some crazy experiments that we’re currently running at Integrated that I probably would not have thought about when I was in Boston,” said Wong, referring to the startup whose name was emblazoned on his vest. Wong considered a career on the East Coast. But as he started trying to turn his lab research into funding for a new venture, he encountered a common problem: Investors in Boston were not biting. They seemed more reluctant than their counterparts on the West Coast to take a risk on young talent.

BIOTECHS, Page A6



JAKUB MOSUR FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

Felix Wong, in his Redwood City, Calif., lab, considered launching a new venture on the East Coast, but couldn’t find investors here.

Encore for a campus that lost its college

Vermont revival a way forward for schools facing closure



By Brooke Hauser
GLOBE STAFF

MARLBORO, Vt. — You can’t miss the sign among the wildflowers at the entrance to the Marlboro Music Festival: “Caution: Musicians at Play.”

For decades, it has welcomed summer visitors to the campus of Marlboro College, a small liberal arts school in southern Vermont. But the sign has new meaning now: Five years ago, Marlboro Music, the nonprofit that runs the festival, bought the 560-acre campus following the college’s closure.

Today the musicians aren’t just at play; they’re at work with donors and trustees transforming a seasonal retreat into a permanent, year-round home. There were some harrowing turns on the road to preserving the idyllic campus that has hosted this esteemed chamber-music festival for 75 years. But the school’s academic legacy lives on via an alliance with Emerson College, which created an interdisciplinary major in its honor. And thanks to the musical haven on Potash Hill, so does its storied past.

As small liberal arts colleges across the Northeast face a mass die-off, and sudden college closures wreak havoc on the

FESTIVAL, Page A10



PHOTOS BY CHRISTIAN KANTOSKY FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

A violin technician worked on repairs (above) and musicians and staff gathered for lunch (top) last month during the Marlboro Music Festival on the former Marlboro College campus in Marlboro, Vt.

He was arrested in Russia in ’22; now his family fears for his life

By Chloe Craft
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

A former US Marine from Massachusetts held in Russia on contested charges for more than four years is now “on the brink of death” as a result of abuse in prison, his family said last week. Robert Gilman, of Lowell, has been in a near catatonic state for weeks in a hospital in southwestern Russia. Global Reach, an advocacy group representing Gilman’s family, said they were alerted on Tuesday that his condition had become life threatening. “He has been non-reactive, unable to

speak, open his eyes, or eat,” said Global Reach chief strategy officer Eric Lebson, who is from Framingham. “All of this is happening while he’s being fed through a feeding tube and handcuffed to a bed guarded by five armed policemen.” Gilman, 32, was moved from prison to a civilian hospital after he fell into a dissociative stupor, a condition in which a person becomes unresponsive as a result of intense stress, according to Lebson. Irina Brazhnikova, Gilman’s lawyer, told Russian news outlets he was placed in the psychiatric ward of a civilian hospital.

PRISONER, Page A3



Couple of hot takes

Sunday: Hazy and hot. High: 90-95. Low: 70-75.
Monday: Same. High: 85-90. Low: 70-75.
High tide: 8:29 a.m. 8:46 p.m.
Sunrise: 5:34 Sunset: 7:54
Complete report, **C20**.
Deaths, **C14-19**.

Sportscasters Bob Lobel and Mike Lynch were competitors, but each showed up for the other when he needed it most. **Globe Magazine**.

Adam Vinatieri, one of the most clutch athletes in Boston sports history, joined the Pro Football Hall of Fame. **C1**.

Boston luxury hotel XV Beacon was rated the best in the country, so travel writer Christopher Muther put it to the test. **Travel, N11**.

The state is pleased with its lottery app, but not everyone else is. **B1**.

“Tony” taps into Anthony Bourdain’s love of Provincetown and spots like the Lobster Pot. Sunday Arts, N1.



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Win, rinse, repeat. Again and again.

Red Sox streak shows how
success can feed on itself

By Alex Speier
GLOBE STAFF

To athletes, momentum is a revered but shapeless concept, an aspiration to an undefined state of being whose existence is not doubted. To question it is to ask whether the sky is blue.

“It’s a real thing,” said Red Sox shortstop Trevor Story. “And it can obviously flip a season on its head.”

Story, of course, was referring to a 2026 Red Sox campaign that has featured an almost unprecedented pairing of extremes.

For nearly half a season, the team — and particularly the lineup — saw failure snowball, leading the team down a 32-46 chasm. With alarming frequency, rallies went nowhere, with the team treating opportunities with men in scoring position like radioactive waste.

And then, as if at the snap of a hypnotist’s fingers, the team transformed into one where all the parts aligned perfectly, where a double followed by a well-placed bunt might be followed by a walk, then a hit, then another.

At-bat to at-bat, game to game, win to win, the Sox rode

RED SOX, Page C6



By Christopher Gavin
and Chris Serres
GLOBE STAFF

By the time investigators found his secret stash, Ronald L. Fischer was long gone.

The 49-year-old was on trial in 2005, accused of sexually assaulting a woman aboard his boat, The Lion King, at a Rhode Island marina. If convicted, he could spend the rest of his life in prison. That was a risk Fischer was unwilling to accept.

A former anesthesiologist with an Ivy League education and an impressive resume, Fischer lived a privileged life. He fussed over his white Jaguar and presented himself to women he was trying to date as a chess master, expert yachtsman, and all-around bon vivant.

“He looked like he thought he was God’s gift to women,” his neighbor told a reporter at the time.

Although Fischer assumed his name would be cleared — a rape charge against him a decade earlier had been downgraded, and he never served time — he was not about to let a jury decide his fate. So, on a Saturday in April 2005, he wrote an email to his attorney with a one-word subject line: “Goodbye.”

“Although I believe my trial has gone very well and expect to be acquitted and dis-

FUGITIVE, Page A8



From top: Ronald L. Fischer in court in July, on a R.I. State Police most wanted list, and in the 1977 Cornell yearbook.

►But then, the Sox lost Saturday. **C1**.